Eleven Days, Ten Years

9:56 P.M.

September 24, 2026. 9:56 p.m.

I had just finished *My Hero Academia*.

I started on September 14. In eleven days, I had watched eight seasons and four movies, which still sounds made up when I say it out loud. I wasn't trying to set a record. I would finish an episode, look at the time, decide I should probably stop, and then start the next one because twenty-three minutes didn't seem like much. There were afternoons when I should have been doing something else and nights when I told myself I would sleep after the current arc. Suddenly I was in Season Six. Then Seven. Then the Final Season.

At the time, it all felt normal. For nearly two weeks, the answer to what I wanted to do next was always waiting on the screen.

U.A. The training camp. A hospital, a school festival, a ruined city. Someone getting hurt; someone else coming back at the worst possible moment. A character I had disliked a few episodes earlier becoming somebody I was genuinely worried about. I could move from one of those places to another without even getting out of my chair.

And at 9:56 p.m., there was no next episode.

I sat there after the credits. The player began recommending other things, and my room looked exactly as it had before I pressed play. I remember finding that oddly offensive. All of this had happened, and nothing around me had changed.

So I opened YouTube and watched other people watch *My Hero Academia*.

For hours.

I knew the ending. I knew what happened to All Might, to One For All, to the people who lived and the ones who didn't. I knew about the eight-year jump. A reaction video had no new plot information to offer me, yet I kept clicking. Sometimes a person would laugh through a scene that had left me silent. Sometimes they talked over a line I had been waiting to hear. I would close the tab, irritated, and try another.

Every so often somebody simply stopped talking. Those were the videos I kept open.

By then a few things had lodged in my head with embarrassing precision. All Might's lunch wrapped in a blue cloth covered with white rabbits and orange carrots. Eri smiling at the school festival. A point in a particular piece of music that made several scenes appear in my mind at once. All Might facing All For One when there was so little left of the version of him I had met at the beginning.

And Shinso. He had finally made it into Class 2-A, and somehow I was annoyed that I hadn't been allowed to see his first perfectly ordinary morning there.

I knew this was an excessive amount of feeling to bring to an anime I had only started eleven days earlier. Knowing didn't help much.

The reaction videos had dates underneath them. Some were from 2022, others from 2019, when I had no idea I would ever care about any of this. The people in those rooms were worrying about questions I had answered yesterday. They had waited months between seasons, sometimes years. Two episodes separated by less than an hour of my life might have had a year of waiting between them for someone else.

I looked at those dates for longer than I expected. On September 14, I had pressed play on Episode One. On September 24, I reached the end of something other people had lived alongside for almost ten years.

I could find out what happened next whenever I wanted, right up until the moment I couldn't. What I had skipped was beginning to feel as important as what I had seen.

I. The Waiting I Skipped

The first season aired in 2016. I wasn't watching it.

After finishing the series, I started noticing the upload dates on old reaction videos in a way I normally wouldn't. A video from 2019 looked ordinary enough until the person in it started making predictions. They could still be wrong. They could spend ten minutes worrying about a question I had resolved in the next episode, and when their video ended, they might have had to live with that uncertainty for months.

I never had to live with it at all.

If an episode ended at midnight, I could know what happened next at 12:23. If a season ended, the following season was already sitting there. I pressed "Next Episode," and that was my timeskip.

Oddly, it didn't feel like I was racing. The show seemed to be moving at the correct speed, while dinner and sleep kept interrupting it. I had Wednesdays, Thursdays, three episodes before a meal, another two after. Sometimes I looked up from the screen and realized I had crossed a season boundary that had once meant a year to somebody else. I had done it because I wasn't quite hungry enough to stop.

What surprised me was how old the characters already felt in my memory.

I had known All Might for less than two weeks. Near the end, though, the thought of a little cloth around a lunch he had made for Deku could make my stomach drop. I watched Shinso struggle to enter the Hero Course, finally get there, and almost at once disappear into the future that the ending skipped. I wanted to know where he sat. This was a character I had met only days before.

Perhaps spending so many hours in the same fictional place is enough to produce familiarity. I don't know. I only know that Season One felt farther away than September 14 had any right to feel.

The music made that distance worse.

I had probably heard "You Say Run" before I watched *My Hero Academia*. It seems to turn up everywhere, often detached from the show. But inside the story I understood its job immediately: Deku runs, somebody needs help, the music rises, and something impossible becomes a little less impossible. Early on, I was happy to follow it wherever it wanted to take me.

That suited the series I thought I was watching. Deku starts with nothing, receives One For All, learns to use a fraction of it, injures himself, tries again. There is another percentage to reach, another technique, another version of himself waiting on the other side of the next fight. The story moves forward, and the music seems to move with it.

After the finale, I played "You Say Run" again. Almost immediately, later images pushed their way into it: All Might without his power, the last stages of One For All, scenes I hadn't even found sad the first time. It annoyed me. I wanted the track to sound the way it had sounded a week earlier.

I restarted it twice, as though I might catch the opening before the later scenes arrived. I couldn't.

I could replay Episode One, but I couldn't unknow the ending while I watched. When All Might appeared, I knew what he would lose. A scene from Season Six could find its way into a moment from Season One without my permission. Some of the old reaction videos let me watch people who still had the earlier version of the story, before the later parts had changed it for them. They were reacting to possibilities. I was reacting with my own memory in the way.

The videos themselves had aged, too. A room changed between uploads; somebody's haircut looked different; an older recording had a slightly different quality. I wasn't keeping notes, and I couldn't tell you every example now. But the dates stayed with me. An episode that aired in 2019 might belong to Tuesday in my head. Something from 2022 might feel like yesterday.

For the people who watched as it aired, whole pieces of their lives existed between those episodes. They finished school years, moved houses, changed their minds about characters, grew up. An unanswered question could sit in the background for a year while everything else continued. I had never given the questions that kind of room.

On September 14, I didn't know Eri. By September 24, I was looking at her older self and missing the little girl I'd met. All Might had gone from an enormous smiling man who made danger seem manageable to someone I could barely bear to see near a battlefield. One For All had moved from the gift I was waiting for Deku to receive to a power I had already watched him give up.

None of those years had passed for me. Still, when I went back to the beginning, it didn't feel like last week.

Maybe that was part of why I watched people reacting to episodes from years ago. They couldn't tell me anything I didn't know, but they could remind me of what it was like not to know. They still had the week after an episode, the year after a finale,

the ordinary days during which a character remained exactly where the story had left them.

I had moved straight through all of those spaces. Now I was trying to imagine what it might have been like to stay in one.

II. The Rabbit Cloth

There is a blue cloth covered with little white rabbits and orange carrots. I remember it more clearly than some of the fights.

I remember the fights, too: All Might throwing punches powerful enough to change the weather, Kamino, the last of One For All burning out of him. I can still picture his huge body collapsing into that thin, exhausted man underneath. Yet when I think about him now, I often see the lunch he made for Deku before I see any of that.

In the beginning, All Might seemed capable of almost anything. He arrived smiling, and the scale of the trouble changed. He gave Deku One For All; before that, he gave him permission to believe that being Quirkless had not already settled the rest of his life. He trained him, watched him break his fingers again and again, worried about him, offered advice that wasn't always good, and kept trying to be a teacher. Meanwhile, his own body was giving out.

The thin version was there from the start. Muscle, smoke, and then a frighteningly tired-looking man who sometimes coughed blood. The contrast was so extreme that I initially treated it as a joke built into the character design. Here was the Symbol of Peace, and here was what he looked like when he could no longer perform that part.

Somewhere along the way I began paying closer attention to the second one.

By the time Deku left U.A., All Might could no longer chase after him as a hero. He couldn't reclaim One For All or force Deku to rest. He couldn't persuade him that vanishing from everyone who loved him was not actually a way to keep them safe. Still, he followed him around, and he brought food.

There was something almost unbearable about the plainness of it. A man who once made crowds feel safe just by arriving had cooked for a teenager who was running himself into the ground. He wrapped the lunch in that blue cloth and went out to find him.

Then Deku walked away, and the food fell.

I understood why he left. He was afraid that anyone close to him would be hurt. By then, being cared for had begun to look dangerous to him. Understanding his reasoning did not make me any less desperate for him to turn around. Take the food. Let All Might do this one thing.

The rabbits and carrots made the scene worse. With a plain lunch bag, I would still have hated watching it, but that cloth felt almost aggressively domestic. Someone had bought it. All Might kept it somewhere in his home, took it out, and used it to wrap lunch. Maybe he liked the pattern. Maybe it was simply the first clean thing he found in a cupboard. I keep thinking about both possibilities.

I had accepted, in theory, that the Symbol of Peace went home at the end of the day. He ate meals, had clothes, opened cupboards, probably owned plenty of boring things. But the story had taught me to picture him on a much larger scale. He was news footage and a smile that could be seen from far away. When he announced "I am here," the words meant the situation was about to become survivable. His presence was nearly a physical force.

Now he could be right beside someone he loved and still be unable to stop him.

I watched that scene with an anger I couldn't direct anywhere useful. Deku didn't need All Might to defeat an enemy for him. He needed food and rest, and All Might was capable of providing both. It should have been an easy thing to accept. Instead, Deku went on alone.

I grew more attached to All Might as he became less certain of what he was supposed to do. For most of his adult life, usefulness had meant something absurdly large. A city needed him; the country needed him. People judged their own safety by whether he was still standing. After Kamino, the work kept going without his power. Other heroes fought, Deku grew stronger, disasters spread, and All Might had to discover what was left for him.

He researched things and took notes. He hovered. He worried. Sometimes he gave advice; sometimes all he could do was watch. I don't think the story ever made him useless. He just seemed to have a hard time believing there were ways of helping that didn't involve saving everybody at once.

Which is why I dreaded his return to the fight with All For One.

He had already lost his old form and the power that made it possible. All For One, infuriatingly, was still there. Then All Might appeared with armor and technology and an almost ridiculous collection of equipment modeled on his students' abilities. Part of me was delighted by the idea. The rest of me spent that fight waiting for something horrible to happen.

Please don't make me watch this man die, I remember thinking.

And then, almost in the same breath: Why are you here?

It wasn't that I thought he lacked courage. I had watched him stand against All For One before, watched him use the last of his strength, watched him keep teaching afterward. He had proved everything I needed him to prove. If I could have reached

through the screen, I might have told him to go home. I wanted someone else to handle it for once.

That would have been an absurd reaction for me during the early seasons. Back then, whenever a situation became desperate, I waited for All Might to arrive. By the end, his appearance near a battlefield frightened me. I had stopped being excited by the question of whether he could win and started thinking about what it would cost him to try.

I can't pinpoint when this changed. Kamino was part of it, though I suspect the shift began earlier. All Might and Toshinori Yagi no longer felt entirely interchangeable in my head. The enormous smiling hero wasn't fake, exactly. I still loved him. But Toshinori was the man who coughed blood, followed Deku even when he couldn't keep up, and apparently had a lunch cloth with rabbits on it.

Then Deku lost One For All as well.

I was sad about that, and I'm still sad. I wanted him to have more time with the thing he had worked so hard to carry. But All Might had already made it impossible for me to believe that losing One For All meant losing the rest of yourself. He had spent so long living after his power was gone. It wasn't graceful, and it wasn't easy, but there he was, still trying to take care of somebody.

The lunch didn't fix anything. Deku didn't stop, didn't eat it, didn't turn around. The food was left on the ground.

I can picture the blue cloth more clearly than I can picture a dozen explosions. That may be the part of All Might I'll carry longest: he couldn't pass on his power again, so he did the next thing he knew how to do. He made lunch.

III. What We Give Away

The first time Deku tried to save Bakugo, he didn't have One For All.

When I first watched that scene, I was impatient for the story to begin. Deku was Quirkless, All Might hadn't trained him, and there were no percentages or extra abilities to keep track of. Bakugo was trapped inside the sludge villain while the pro heroes hesitated, and Deku ran into the middle of it with no plan and almost nothing he could actually do.

All Might chose him because he ran in anyway.

The show tells us that almost immediately. Somehow, after eight seasons of watching Deku grow stronger, I had managed to reverse it in my head. I thought of him as a person who saved people because he had been given power. But he received the power because he had already tried to save someone. The order matters.

Hands appear all over *My Hero Academia*. I didn't notice at first, and I get a little suspicious of myself whenever I start spotting a motif. There is a danger of turning a story into an English assignment against its will: circle an image, call it a symbol, write a paragraph about what it represents. Still, by the end I had a difficult time ignoring all those outstretched hands.

There's the old moment between Bakugo and Deku, when Bakugo falls and Deku offers to help him up. Deku means exactly what he seems to mean. Are you okay? Do you need help? Bakugo sees pity and superiority instead. One child reaches out, and the other spends years resenting it.

And there's Tenko, walking alone while adults notice him and keep going. Each seems to assume someone else will handle it. By the time a person finally reaches for

him, that person is All For One. I found it hard to watch that sequence without thinking about all the small opportunities that had passed before he arrived.

Late in the series, Deku develops almost the opposite problem. He has spent so much time running toward other people's danger that he starts treating his own presence as a threat. He leaves U.A., stops eating and sleeping properly, and keeps moving. People try to follow him; he keeps explaining why they should stay away.

I understood his logic. I was also furious with him.

Iida finally catches up and holds on to him. It's a simple reversal, but seeing it happen after so many seasons made it land harder than I expected. Deku had built his whole sense of himself around arriving in time for others. Now someone was arriving for him, and he had to be convinced to let that count as help.

The final battle returns to the same problem on a much larger scale. Deku sees Tenko somewhere inside Shigaraki, a child who was never reached when it might have changed everything. Defeating Shigaraki is no longer enough for him. He wants to save the person buried inside, too.

I wasn't always on board with that. Too many people had died. There was so much damage that the insistence on saving him could sound almost cruel to everyone who hadn't been saved from him. I didn't want the story to act as if reaching Tenko would somehow erase what Shigaraki had done.

It doesn't erase it. Deku reaches anyway, knowing that he may not be able to bring him back. I still have mixed feelings about the attempt, but the scene has stayed with me partly because it refuses the easier idea that you only offer help when you're confident it will work.

Near the end, another lonely child appears, and an ordinary woman makes the choice that nobody made for Tenko. She stops and offers her hand.

That moment can't rescue Tenko retroactively. It happens to someone else, years too late for him. I think that's why it works for me. The story has no way to return to the exact street where everyone walked past a suffering child. What it can show is someone taking a different path when another child needs help.

Monoma was an entirely different kind of satisfaction.

For most of the series, Neito Monoma was the loud boy from Class 1-B who couldn't encounter Class 1-A without finding a reason to start something. He annoyed me so consistently that I had more or less accepted annoyance as his purpose in the story.

Then the final war began, and I was suddenly rooting for him to be as insufferable as he liked.

I had watched Aizawa suffer through the first war trying to maintain Erasure. He lost an eye and cut off his own leg before the Quirk-destroying drug could spread. He survived, but the damage mattered. Erasure was one of the few abilities capable of restraining Shigaraki at all, and Aizawa couldn't simply appear for the next fight in the condition he had been in before.

The story didn't magically repair him. Instead, it gave Monoma an extraordinary job.

He copied Kurogiri's Warp Gate. The portals opened, heroes came through, and the plan the heroes had spent so long preparing suddenly had a way to move everyone into place. The gates separated people across the battlefield; Shigaraki was sent toward U.A., and the war split into several fights. Watching those portals open was one of the few moments in that arc when I felt able to enjoy the cleverness of the plan without immediately worrying about who would be hurt next.

And then Monoma copied Erasure.

There he was at U.A., staring at Shigaraki and keeping his Quirks suppressed. The boy whose ability was called Copy, who could only use a power by borrowing somebody else's, had become essential to the entire operation. For years he'd behaved as if he had something to prove to everyone within hearing distance. Watching him do this, I wanted to say, Go ahead. Talk your shit. You've earned it.

What I especially liked was that it didn't undo the earlier losses. Aizawa still had one eye and one leg. Monoma had not become Aizawa, and Kurogiri's Warp Gate wasn't suddenly his forever. He took what others could lend him, used it while he could, and made a difference that remained after the borrowed powers were gone.

One For All operates differently, or at least it seemed to for most of the series. All Might gives it to Deku, and Deku spends years learning how to hold it. Every new percentage is a sign of progress. The vestiges of its earlier holders become more important, and the whole history of the power seems to be pushing toward a future in which Deku can finally use everything they've passed on.

That is part of why *Heroes Rising*, the second movie, unsettled me so much.

Deku gives One For All to Bakugo when the fight becomes desperate. I knew there were seasons after the movie. I knew the story wasn't really ending there. But Deku didn't make the decision with that knowledge. As far as he was concerned, he was sacrificing the power he'd spent so much of his life trying to deserve.

Then "Might+U" starts playing.

I can't settle on a word for what that music does. The fight is spectacular, with Deku and Bakugo throwing around more power than either should reasonably be able to survive. It ought to feel like the cleanest kind of triumph. Instead, there's a gentleness to the music that makes me feel as though the scene is already mourning

something. They are winning, and I am thinking about what Deku believes he has lost to make winning possible.

I assumed that was a one-time exception. The main story had other plans.

Near the end, giving One For All away becomes the strategy. I understood why the vestiges needed to be transferred into Shigaraki. I understood the attempt to break through to Tenko. I still remember staring at the screen and thinking, Really? After everything?

We had spent so long measuring how much more Deku could carry. Five percent, eight percent, twenty. Techniques, injuries, months of practice, another holder's Quirk, another step toward the power All Might believed he could grow into. Then the direction changed. He began letting the vestiges go, one after another, dismantling something generations had built.

There is a version of the ending I still want, even knowing it isn't the one I watched. In that version Deku manages to save people and somehow keeps One For All. It's probably too convenient. He worked so hard for it, though. That isn't a particularly sophisticated argument, but it was the first thing I felt.

I keep coming back to Monoma and All Might whenever I think about it. Monoma could borrow extraordinary powers without owning them; what he did with them still counted. All Might had lost the power at the center of his public identity and continued to care for people in whatever ways were left to him. Neither example makes me cheer for Deku's loss. They do make it harder to claim that everything he became disappeared along with One For All.

At the beginning, he ran toward Bakugo with nothing in his hands. Near the end, those same hands carried the accumulated strength and hopes of All Might, Nana

Shimura, and all the people who came before them. He let that go to reach somebody who might not even have been able to reach back.

I still hate watching One For All disappear. But I keep going back to what Deku did before he ever had it: he saw somebody in trouble and ran toward him.

IV. The Years We Didn't See

Shinso made it into the Hero Course. I had been waiting for that.

Not for eight years, obviously. For me it had only been a few days. But I had seen him arrive at the Sports Festival with a Quirk that sounded like something a villain would use, already wearing the expression of someone exhausted by that comparison. He lost to Deku, trained with Aizawa, and returned during the joint exercises looking far more capable and far more at home.

When he was finally told he could transfer, I was happy for him. After Aoyama left, Shinso would join Class 2-A. I knew that much from the ending. What I wanted was the part that happened between the announcement and everybody getting used to him being there.

Who spoke to him first when he walked into the classroom? Did the others make a fuss? Was it awkward for a week? Did Kaminari annoy him on the first day, or did that take longer? I wanted to see the morning when something he'd fought so hard for began turning into a normal part of his life.

The story had spent plenty of time making his arrival matter. Then it moved so quickly through the future that I barely saw him arrive.

After the war, time expands and contracts in a few sentences. Buildings are rebuilt, school continues, another year begins. Second year, third year, graduation, eight

years later. Those labels cover an enormous amount of life. I've had school years that seemed incapable of ending. An ending can pass over one in a line or two.

Somewhere in the years we didn't see, there must have been days when nobody nearly died. Bad lunches, forgotten homework, somebody nodding off in class. Arguments that lasted an afternoon and were never mentioned again. A class ending five minutes early.

Shinso having a completely unremarkable Tuesday. The idea of those days made me miss the characters more than another fight would have.

That may be why I keep returning to the School Festival.

By then, a great deal had already gone wrong. All Might had retired, the students had been through more than they should have, and Eri had survived things I would rather not dwell on. For a little while, though, the task in front of everyone was to put on a concert. They had to rehearse, get the timing right, organize people, and try to give one girl a good day.

The heroes had rescued Eri from Overhaul, but being physically safe wasn't the same as knowing how to be happy again. After all the fighting it took to get her out, she still couldn't quite smile. Saving her body had been violent and spectacular. Making her happy required a band.

When Eri finally smiled, nothing about her past vanished. She simply had a moment of happiness that belonged to her. I remember feeling relieved in a way no victory in the previous arc had made me feel.

And then there's “Shout Baby.”

Something about that ending song, especially the photographs, makes it difficult for me to keep a safe distance from the story. I remember an image of Aizawa as a

student, standing beside people who, in the photograph, are still only his classmates. Of course he looks younger. What gets me is that they don't know what is coming. They're just in a school photograph, together, on an ordinary day.

I cried at that image. I also had the completely unreasonable thought that maybe the series should end there.

It couldn't, and I knew it. Shigaraki was still out there. One For All had much further to go. Some of the scenes I now care about most hadn't happened yet. Even so, I wanted a little more time at that school, when the students were still together, Eri was smiling, and Aizawa was mostly just the tired teacher at the front of the classroom. All Might was nearby. Deku still had One For All. Nobody had graduated.

When I first reached the School Festival, it was simply another part of the show. Only later, after I knew the ending, did it begin to feel like a place I wanted to return to.

Deku kept the embers of One For All after the final battle. For a while.

That part of the ending bothers me in a quieter way than the final fight. We learn that the embers eventually went out, which makes sense for the story, but I wonder what living through that would have been like. Did he notice every time a little strength was gone? Was there a day when he couldn't do something he'd managed the month before? Did he realize when he used it for the last time?

I imagine it happening without much ceremony. Less power than before, and then less again. A school year passing around him. The approach of graduation. One ordinary day when there was nothing left.

While that was happening, Eri was growing up. Shinso was becoming a regular member of the Hero Course instead of the boy trying to get in. The first-years

stopped being first-years. Aizawa kept teaching. Everyone got older, often in ways the ending had no reason to show us.

Usually, when a story jumps forward, I want missing information. Who ended up where? Who became what? This time I knew the important answers. They grew up, they became heroes, and Deku became a teacher. I didn't need a new villain or a hidden plot twist to fill the gap.

I wanted the missing Tuesdays.

A Tuesday in second year when everybody went to class and went home. A Wednesday when training finished early. One of those disposable stretches of life that barely registers while you're living it because you assume there will be another tomorrow. I had spent eleven days watching the most important things that happened to these people, and at the end I found myself longing for the least important.

I wanted to see where Shinso sat. I wanted Deku to have One For All for one more ordinary day.

V. Friends

There's a point in "Friends," a little after the one-minute mark, when listening to the music stops feeling like listening to music. Around 1:10, a few notes come in and I start seeing scenes from *My Hero Academia* whether I want to or not.

Deku after saving Kota. The ending of the first movie. The ending of the second. Sometimes a different image gets there first, and sometimes several arrive so quickly that I can't tell which one I thought of before the others.

It happens even when I'm sitting alone with nothing playing on a screen. I know the change in the music is coming, but I can't really prepare for it. The pictures turn up on their own.

The one I remember most easily is the still of Deku after the fight to save Kota. The fighting is over; Kota is safe. Somehow the image of Deku afterward comes to me faster than many of the blows that got him there. I spent eleven days watching people smash through buildings, and my memory decided that quiet figure was what it wanted to keep.

Then a movie ending appears, and then another. Those scenes weren't released together, and they don't belong to the same part of the story. In my head the distances between them have become small. “Friends” plays, and everything sits beside everything else.

I think this is one of the strangest things eleven days did to my memory. Season Three is only a few days away from the Final Season. A movie is something I watched on another night. I took the story in order, but I didn't give the different parts enough time to settle into separate periods of my life. My memory hasn't kept a tidy record of what belongs where. It uses the music as a shortcut.

I sometimes wonder what “Friends” would have sounded like to me before September 14. Probably just a song. I don't have a childhood memory of hearing it or an older version of myself attached to it. As far as I can tell, on September 13 none of those images existed for me. Less than two weeks later, one minute and ten seconds of music could make me cry. I gave everything eleven days. Apparently that was enough.

The precision of that timestamp is ridiculous. I couldn't tell you the episode number of every scene I loved. Some dialogue is already slipping away from me; I mix up the order of certain fights and occasionally have to check where a moment happened.

Yet I know exactly where to move the playback bar when I want to hear that part of "Friends."

At first I was bothered by how quickly I was forgetting things. I'd only just finished the show. How could so much already be blurry? But the more I tried to recall, the clearer it became that my memory hadn't kept everything with equal care. The rabbit cloth was still there. So was the question of Shinso's seat. So was 1:10.

Those weren't necessarily the most important moments by any reasonable measure. They were the ones that caught somewhere and stayed.

I still play the track. When that passage arrives, I usually know what I'm seeing before I can even put a name to it. Sometimes it's Deku, sometimes the end of a movie, sometimes a jumble of scenes from completely different seasons. I've stopped trying to force them back into the right order. For a minute, they're simply there again.

VI. After the Last Episode

After the last episode, I returned to YouTube. Again.

By then I knew what most reaction videos looked like before opening them: an episode number, an exaggerated expression next to a character's face, a title announcing that somebody had LOST IT or WAS NOT READY. I'd click and get another twenty or forty minutes during which the story was happening to someone for the first time.

I had already seen the ending. They hadn't. For a while, that difference was enough to keep me watching.

Then I got annoyingly particular. A person would laugh at a moment that had left me frozen. Somebody would start explaining a theory just as a character said

something I'd waited seasons to hear. Once, a reactor shouted "YO, BRO—" over a scene I loved, and I closed the tab almost on instinct.

This was unfair. These people ran reaction channels. Talking was rather central to the job. I was watching strangers on the internet and getting irritated because they weren't following a set of rules I had invented about five minutes earlier. I knew how unreasonable I was being, but I still kept looking for a different video.

I had also carried around a small, slightly embarrassing fantasy about going to the United States. I imagined anime might feel less private there—not that everybody would love it, only that I might have to explain myself less before talking about it. Somewhere inside that fantasy was the hope that finding people who recognized the same characters would make it easier to find people who felt the same things.

American reaction videos complicated that idea pretty quickly. Someone could love *My Hero Academia*, know it far better than I did, and still laugh at a scene that made me cry. We had recognized the same story without having the same experience of it.

I tried Japanese reactions, VTubers, and channels from places I knew almost nothing about. Some people cried and joked in the space of five minutes. Some talked constantly; others barely spoke. Age didn't help much, nor nationality, nor the number of anime figures on a shelf behind somebody's chair. I had been imagining a kind of community in which a shared interest would automatically produce a shared response. The actual people were more complicated than that.

Eventually I noticed what made me stay.

A familiar scene would begin, and the person in the corner of the screen would fall silent. Maybe their expression changed. Maybe they covered their mouth. Maybe they kept looking at the screen after the credits started. I didn't need them to say

anything clever about the writing or explain why the scene was sad. I was simply relieved when they stopped in the same place I had.

It took me longer than it should have to understand what I wanted from those videos. I wasn't looking for confirmation that the anime was good. Nor did I need somebody else's tears to make my own reaction legitimate. I had been sitting in my room with a headache from watching far too many episodes. When a soundtrack came on the following day, my chest tightened before I had even decided which scene I was remembering. Whatever caused that feeling, I knew I'd felt it.

But it was strangely comforting to see it happen to someone else.

You too? Here?

That was the question underneath all those clicks.

The answer was often no. Someone laughed, missed a line, or paused at precisely the wrong time to explain something I no longer cared about. Over time I became less angry at them. They weren't taking a test I had written. They were watching the show from inside their own lives, with their own memories and expectations. I had brought eleven very crowded days to it. Other people had sometimes waited a year between seasons and had time to let one feeling settle before the next arrived.

I hadn't. Kamino was still close when I reached the final war. The School Festival hadn't had time to feel nostalgic until the ending made me miss it. All Might went from someone I wanted to see win fights to someone I wanted kept away from them before two weeks of my life had passed. Maybe everything was still too near for me to bear hearing someone laugh at the wrong moment.

Every now and then, though, a stranger in an old video would go quiet exactly when I had.

It was a smaller kind of recognition than I'd imagined when I pictured a crowd of people who understood. I didn't know the person. They didn't know I was watching. We might have disagreed about everything else in the episode. For a few seconds, across different years and different rooms, we seemed to be attending to the same thing.

Eventually it got late. No amount of clicking had brought the series back. The people in it were fictional, and the people watching were strangers who would go on with their days after the video ended. But for a few seconds, someone years ago could stop talking in front of a screen, and I could sit in front of mine in September 2026 and understand exactly why.

Epilogue — Inheritance

September 24, 2026. 9:56 p.m.

That was when I finished *My Hero Academia*. I remember the exact time because it was the first moment in eleven days when I didn't know what to do next.

Before then, there had always been another episode, another movie, another piece of music I hadn't heard yet. There were characters I barely noticed at first and would soon care about far more than I expected. I didn't have to wonder where to go after any of it. I just kept watching.

The people who followed the show as it aired spent years with it. I skipped nearly all of their waiting, but I could still find traces of it in old reaction videos, old comments, songs that had been carrying other people's memories long before they carried mine.

And now, I suppose, this is here too.

I don't know when I'll watch the series again. It might be soon, or it might be years from now. I know it won't feel like those first eleven days. The music will already contain the scenes that come later. I'll notice details I missed, misremember others, and probably wonder why I was so upset about something that made complete sense at the time.

That seems fair. I was already losing the first experience while I was having it, even as I tried to keep every part of it close.

At 9:56 p.m., I thought I had reached the point where there was nothing next.

I was wrong about that.

There was just no next episode.